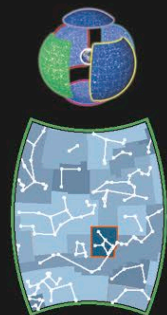


THE CUP

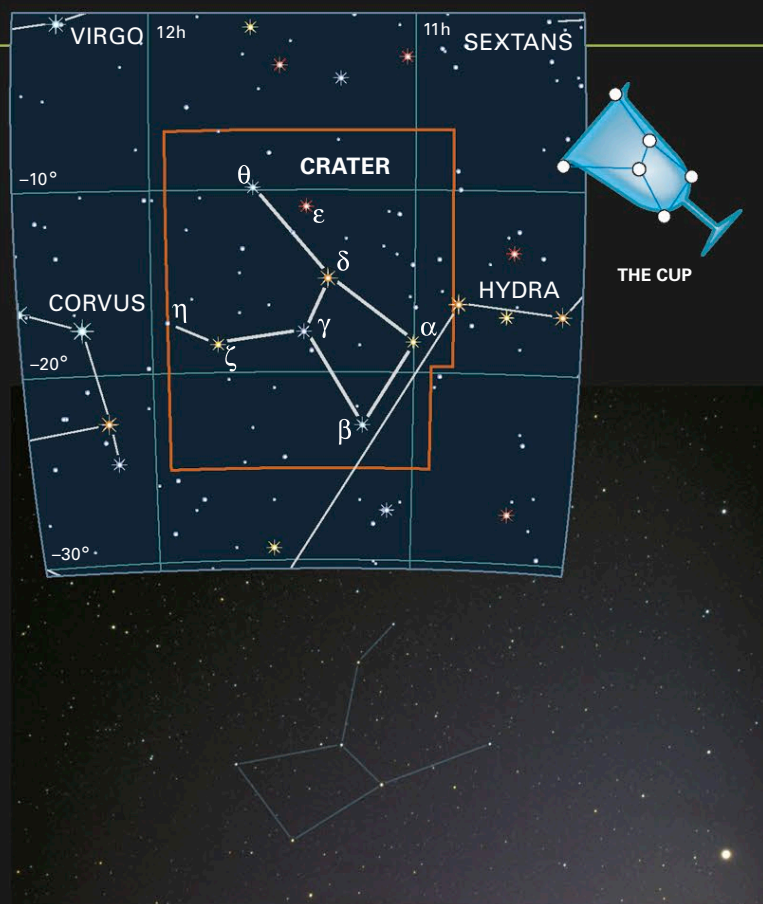
Crater



SIZE RANKING	53
BRIGHTEST STAR	Delta (δ) 3.6
GENITIVE	Crateris
ABBREVIATION	Crt
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM	April
FULLY VISIBLE	65°N–90°S

Crater is a faint constellation representing a cup. Although larger than Corvus, to which it is linked in Greek myth (see panel, right), Crater contains no objects that might be of interest to users of small telescopes.

This area once contained two other constellations that have since been dropped by astronomers. In the late 18th century, a French astronomer, J. J. Lalande, introduced Felis, the cat, between Hydra and Antlia, while others introduced Noctua, the night owl, on the tail of Hydra (see panel illustration, right).



MYTHS AND STORIES

CROW AND CUP

Crater and Corvus feature together in a Greek myth in which the god Apollo sent the crow (Corvus) to fetch water in a cup (Crater). On the way, the greedy crow stopped to eat figs. As an alibi, the crow snatched up a water snake (Hydra) and blamed it for delaying him, but Apollo saw through the deception and banished the trio to the skies.

HISTORIC DEPICTION

The area around Crater as shown in *Urania's Mirror*, a set of 19th-century constellation cards.

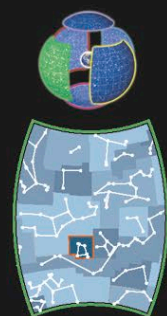


CELESTIAL VESSEL

Crater is to be found lying next to Corvus on the back of Hydra, the water snake. This undistinguished constellation is also known as the Goblet or the Chalice.

THE CROW

Corvus



SIZE RANKING	70
BRIGHTEST STAR	Gamma (γ) 2.6
GENITIVE	Corvi
ABBREVIATION	Crv
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM	April–May
FULLY VISIBLE	65°N–90°S

The four brightest stars of Corvus—Beta (β), Gamma (γ), Delta (δ), and Epsilon (ε) Corvi—form a distinctive keystone shape in this small constellation south of Virgo. Oddly, the star labeled Alpha (α) Corvi, at magnitude 4.0, is significantly fainter than all of these. Corvus is one of the original 48 Greek constellations and represents a crow, the sacred bird of the Greek god Apollo.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

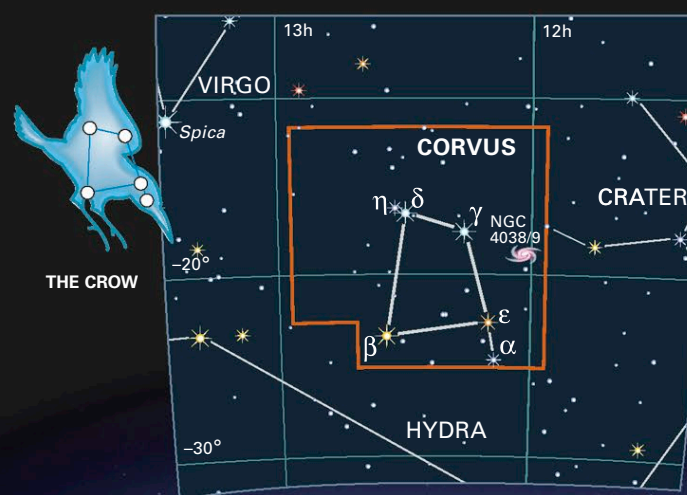
Delta is a double star with components of 3rd and 9th magnitudes. It is divisible through a small telescope.

Corvus also boasts a remarkable pair of interacting galaxies: NGC 4038 and 4039. At 10th magnitude, they are too faint to be seen through a small telescope, but photographs reveal this as a graphic example of a galactic collision. When the galaxies passed each other, gravity pulled out stars and gas to create a shape like an insect's feelers, hence their popular name, the Antennae (see p.317).



THE ANTENNAE

As NGC 4038 and 4039 sweep past each other, gravity draws out long streams of dust and gas from them. The streams extend off the top and bottom of this picture.



PECKING BIRD

Corvus, the crow, is linked in legend with neighboring Crater, the cup. The crow is visualized as pecking at Hydra, the water snake, on whose back it stands.